

MONGOOSES

Mongoose are small, slender-bodied, mostly ground-dwelling carnivores in the family Herpestidae. They live in warm temperate to tropical parts of Africa and Eurasia. Some species live in complex social groups. Together with the Malagasy carnivores, mongooses are thought to be closely related to hyenas.

26–46 cm
10–18 in

wedge-shaped head

YELLOW MONGOOSE

Cynictis penicillata
Inhabiting dry savanna in southern Africa, this mongoose lives in groups led by a dominant male, but forages independently.

sharp, non-retractile claws

16–23 cm
6½–9 in

COMMON DWARF MONGOOSE

Helogale parvula

This small, energetic carnivore forages in packs in African grassland, woodland, and brush country. It eats large invertebrates, such as crickets and scorpions.

45–53 cm
18–21 in

INDIAN GREY MONGOOSE

Urva edwardsii

Frequenting forests and plantations, this species often hunts close to human habitation, where it makes itself useful by killing mice and rats.

39–47 cm
15½–18½ in

RUDDY MONGOOSE

Urva smithii

This little-known Indian forest-dweller hunts birds, reptiles, and smaller mammals. Its tail is sometimes longer than its body.

WHITE-TAILED MONGOOSE

Ichneumia albicauda
Found in dry habitats in Africa and the southern part of the Arabian Peninsula, this large insect-eater also feeds on vertebrates and ripe berries.

47–69 cm
18½–27 in

COMMON CUSIMANSE

Crossarchus obscurus

This forest-dwelling animal from W. Africa lives and hunts in nomadic troops. It is said to make an excellent pet.

30–37 cm
12–14½ in

BANDED MONGOOSE

Mungos mungo

Found in troops in sub-Saharan woodland, this mongoose lives in dens, often excavated in termite mounds. Males and females can lead their troop deep into a neighbouring troop's home range in pursuit of copulations.

30–40 cm
12–16 in

EGYPTIAN MONGOOSE

Herpestes ichneumon

Not restricted to Egypt, this grizzled grey mongoose occurs in open grassy habitats from Spain to South Africa.

coat marked with broken bands

33–48 cm
13–19 in

INDIAN BROWN MONGOOSE

Urva fusca

This uncommon species occupies the jungles of S. India and Sri Lanka. Like other mongooses, it can kill snakes, but prefers easier prey.

slender tail

SLENDER MONGOOSE

Galerella sanguinea

A widespread species in Africa, the slender mongoose generally lives alone. It is active by day and busiest just before dusk.

32–34 cm
12½–13½ in

pointed nose

MEERKAT

Suricata suricatta

This species lives in groups in semi-desert habitats. All members help babysit, maintain the burrow, and take it in turns standing sentry while others forage.

24–29 cm
9½–11½ in